

former junior national gold medallist).

Having worked with India's all-time great in the sport, Klaus is aware of the gulf in quality. "In Germany, when we were trying to develop talent, we would say it was like making candy from sh\*t. Here, it's like making a diamond from the dung heap. It's a different kind of challenge, but a new challenge," he shrugs.

Klaus hadn't imagined he would be back in India so soon. When the 73-year-old retired after parting ways with Neeraj last year, he had been looking forward to going home. "I first told Neeraj about retiring after the Tokyo Games, but he convinced me to stay for some more time. He told me, 'Coach, it's just another three years until Paris.' So, I stayed. But both of us knew that I was going to leave after that. So, after Paris, he didn't try too hard to make me stay," says Klaus.

Klaus' home is in the village of Oberschlettenbach, located in south-west Germany, just across the French border. The difference between Oberschlettenbach and Hisar is stark. The former is home to just 130 residents, with pleasant summers, scenic hiking trails, forested mountains, and old castles built during the Holy Roman Empire. At the heart of his village is a fountain that draws crystal-clear drinking water from the surrounding mountains. Hisar, in contrast, is a bustling industrial town of over three lakh people, with temperatures reaching 45 degrees Celsius.

Oberschlettenbach might be idyllic, but Klaus' first project was yard work. "In six years, everything had been growing too much. I had to bring everything to order. In

my time at the Olympics.

I think they found it interesting, which was nice," he says.

It was impossible to keep him away from the sports ground, though. Klaus has been mentoring Swiss heptathlete Lucia Acklin for a while. "When Neeraj and I were in Switzerland, I contacted this young heptathlete, who trained with us. Neeraj gave her some advice as well. Then last year, she won a silver medal at the World Championships (in Lima). That was quite good," he recalls.

But Klaus was also returning to the grassroots. "There's a small club run by the administration of the town near my village. It's about 50 km away, but I'd go there and coach the children in javelin and discus. They only pay 12 euros an hour – like minimum wage – but it's something I enjoyed doing," he recalls.

It was around this time that Manisha Malhotra, president of Inspire Institute Sport, offered him the role of consultant in Hisar. "Manisha was like 'don't let him go so easily out of India. Let him come back and help us to work with our younger throwers'. So, we thought about such a project," Klaus says.

Klaus admits he has a secondary motive to return to India. "I love the mountains. Wherever I go as a coach, I make it a point to go to the mountains. When I was in China, I travelled to the Pamirs near the Afghanistan border. One of the reasons I chose to come to India as a coach was because I'd always wanted to see the majestic Himalayas. I first explored them near Shimla, then I travelled from Mussoorie down the Yamuna, and

« One of Neeraj's greatest strengths is his creativity. He is always curious about various exercises – why something worked and why others didn't. He is always looking for ways to improve – Klaus Bartonietz »

November, I was cutting overgrown trees for firewood. Then at the start of winter, I collected wild mushrooms. In the spring, there were flowers to be planted, and the apple and cherry trees were blossoming," he recalls, in a conversation with *Sportstar*.

Klaus and his wife also visited family members, something he never had time for during his previous stint in India. "My daughter is in Australia, so I was able to fly there and visit my two granddaughters. I told them about

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